was an early indication of how serious a threat the BJP had become to the SP's OBC vote bank. Mayawati and Mulayam tried to reignite the image of 1993—the unity of Backwards and Dalits—to take on the BJP's Hindutva plank. By questioning his caste and class background, Mayawati sought to reinforce the image of her party and her alliance as a defender of the 'pichhda' and the 'Dalit'. The gambit did not pay off.

Modi's response to the political thrust against his background reflected both a mix of his own positioning as a son of the soil—which is so central to his political imagery—as well as his party's tactics of splintering the OBC vote to pick it up piece by piece. Significantly, he chose to respond at an election rally in the Yadav bastion of Kannauj, with a quintessentially unique and direct play on words. As he put it:

You must have seen in so many previous elections that after the first 1-2-3 phases, they start asking what jaat [caste] is Modi from? Somebody says Modi is from a 'neech jaati' [Backward Caste]. Somebody says he is 'neech' [lowly, a reference to Priyanka Gandhi's comment in 2014] … I have never been in favour of politics in the name of caste. Till my opponents did not abuse me, this country did not even know what my caste is. But now I am grateful to Behenji, Akhilesh ji, Congress and all the Mahamilawatis [great adulterators] that they are openly discussing my pichhdapan [backward identity] … Behenji and Mihamilawati people, my caste is small, so small … I was not born in a pichhda [backward] but in an ati-pichhda [most backward] caste. You are making me say it from my mouth, so I am saying it … I have never been an advocate of backward–forward [caste] politics. When my country is backward then what is forward? I want to make the whole country forward. But when you are talking of Forwards and Backwards and distributing proof-certificates of my caste, then let me tell you that my caste is ati-pichhdee [most backward] and it is very small.[38]

Modi's characterisation of his social origins as being from a 'most backward caste' went to the heart of the BJP's electoral positioning as the protector of those lowest down in the social